

THE UNRELIABLE NARRATOR

I executed a working installation that could be categorized as an immersive piece of theatre. My initial problem was surrounding how to design a space where the audience member has a more active and participatory role in a performative piece. Striving to encourage the user to be more inquisitive of their environment and discover the material agency of the inanimate elements of the scene. The only issue was, how was I going to construct such a large scale piece in a gallery space and with such a tight personal budget.

Originally, I was challenged to just create a much smaller-scale or modular version of my project, but I just did not feel that the impact or experience would equate to the overall subject and sensation that I was trying to create with this design. I knew that I needed the piece to be big enough to feel performative but intimate enough that it would fit into our gallery space and not break the budget. So over the months it took to create, I collected mostly discarded materials, (wood, furniture, and antiques) and repurposed them to assemble and decorate my installation. I would describe my approach in the beginning as a free form exploration, similar to sculpture, to help me derive the story from the piece. And as the installation came together I pieced together a loose character and non-linear narrative for the user to discover.

In doing so, I devised the idea of creating a solitary and personal environment where the user could feel a sense of being in control of this theatrical hypertext. The subjects of the installation's narrative sparked a conversation about private and public personas, and in real time offered the ability to comprehend a piece of fiction in a physical and tactile form. My goal was to allow the user to "read" this hypertext, but in order to do so they must immerse themselves in the character and analyze their memories. The user needed to become emotionally and psychologically involved in the character of the story, and in doing so really become a performer of the piece.

The piece was successful because it forced you to ask questions like: How do we take on a different personality, and can we differentiate/familiarize this from our own identity? What does it really take to understand character or persona? And will we be inquisitive enough to discover more of this narrative by complying to interaction with the structure?

Through this softly guided narrative, via theatrical triggers that drove the story forward, I had the user play and engage with the objects in the built vessel (fit for one person) dressing it with props and inanimate material, creating a cabinet of curiosities. But these actually not-so-inanimate objects were the focal points of memory for the character.

The participant interpreted the story by examining the remnants of a fictional person and pursued an investigation of character; finding key objects that provided sensors that triggered the mood of the room (ex. Light change, sound cues, music, vibration, and other theatrical devices.) As they navigated through these actions they were provided a complete sense of their character and the life that the environment and the objects had which ultimately achieved my original goal of an immersive user experience.

Building something so large scale that included so much set and prop decoration, that also included sensors to be installed, rigged, and programmed, was no easy task. If I were to do this project again, I would love to create a larger piece of immersive theatre but it would have to be done with more collaborators, which was the one component I was missing with this journey.

By creating this project, I have in fact learned that this piece has allowed users to feel a sense of storytelling and play, along with becoming more attuned to their environment and the vibrant matter that exists in it. I would like to think of this as an exercise in redefining the way theatre and performance is presented and the roles of the spectator and participants.